

What else to watch: *Le jour se lève* (1939) ■ *Gone with the Wind* (1939, p.62–63) ■ *Le Colonel Chabert* (1943) ■ *Phantom of the Opera* (1943) ■ *An American in Paris* (1951) ■ *The Last Metro* (1980)



The mime sequences were developed by Jean-Louis Barrault (who plays Baptiste, left), and his teacher, Étienne Decroux (who plays Baptiste's father).

heroism. The production team also included Jews in hiding, whose identities were kept secret—in particular designer Alexandre Trauner and composer Joseph Kosma. Trauner lived with Carné during filming under an assumed name, while Kosma's work was credited to Maurice Thiriet, who arranged the music for orchestra.

Boulevard du Crime

There were endless logistical headaches assembling the movie's gigantic set, which Carné built in Nice, in southern France. It was 1,300 ft (400 m) long, and while building materials were scarce, he somehow recreated a street that resembled the famous Boulevard du Temple in Paris during the early 19th century. The street was nicknamed the Boulevard du Crime for the crime melodramas popular

“I’d spill torrents of blood to give you a river of diamonds.”

Pierre François Lacenaire / Children of Paradise

in its lowbrow theaters. At one point during the shoot, when an Allied invasion of southern France was expected, the production was forced to abandon Nice and move to Paris, only to find on their return that the set had been ruined by storms. It had to be completely rebuilt.

Despite these problems, Carné and his team succeeded in creating a lavish and technically brilliant movie, and in coaxing unforgettable performances from the cast. The star, Arletty, oozes

sexual allure in her portrayal of Garance, entrancing the four men who are competing for her love.

Historical suitors

Three of these suitors are based on real historical figures: Jean-Louis Barrault plays the mime artist Baptiste Deburau, who transformed the role of Pierrot into a poignant, childlike character; Pierre Brasseur plays the actor Frédéric Lemaître; and Marcel Herrand the suave criminal Pierre François Lacenaire. The fourth character, the cynical aristocrat Édouard de Monray, »



The movie opened in liberated Paris in 1945, and proved such a success that it played for more than a year. It was credited with helping to restore French national pride.